

Case Study: Everspring Inn – Illegal Evictions, Life-Safety Neglect, and Data Manipulation

Property: 8201 Aurora Ave N, Seattle, WA 98103

Owner/Manager: Myung Ha "Ryan" Kang

Agencies Implicated: Seattle Department of Construction & Inspections (SDCI), Seattle Police Department (SPD)

This case study documents a catastrophic failure of municipal oversight during a public health emergency, where vulnerable tenants were illegally displaced while regulatory agencies systematically ignored evidence of housing code violations, fraudulent record-keeping, and landlord intimidation. The evidence reveals not merely bureaucratic inefficiency, but a pattern of deliberate administrative closures that circumvented state and local tenant protections during Washington's COVID-19 eviction moratorium.



Executive Summary

While Washington's COVID-19 eviction moratorium was in force to protect vulnerable populations during an unprecedented pandemic, Everspring Inn tenants were subjected to illegal lockouts, utility shutoffs, and threats of police action. Between July and September 2020, multiple complaints—each documenting active evictions with photographic evidence and proof of legal tenancy—were administratively closed on the same day they were filed, with no physical inspection conducted.

Zero Inspections

Every complaint filed during the eviction moratorium was closed administratively within 24 hours, despite documented evidence of illegal evictions, utility shutoffs, and armed intimidation.

Never Registered

The property has never been registered under Seattle's Rental Registration & Inspection Ordinance (RRIO) from 1983 through 2025, operating outside legal oversight for over four decades.

Lapsed Certifications

Elevator and fire-system certificates expired while inspection fees accumulated unpaid, yet the City continued billing for services never rendered and allowed continued occupancy.

Perhaps most disturbing, city records later revealed mismatched intake dates and 2023 record numbers assigned to complaints filed in 2020, indicating possible post-hoc manipulation of public records. This suggests an effort to obscure the administrative failures documented in this case study, raising serious questions about data integrity and accountability within SDCI's complaint-tracking system.

Human Toll



Forced Displacement During a Pandemic

As COVID-19 case counts surged and hospitals reached capacity, Everspring Inn tenants faced a manufactured housing crisis engineered by their landlord and enabled by city negligence. Tenants returned home to find:

- Fire exits boarded shut, creating life-threatening egress violations
- Hot water systems deliberately disabled during a pandemic requiring frequent handwashing
- Armed private security guards stationed at entrances to intimidate residents
- Personal belongings removed or disposed of without legal process
- Locks changed on residential units while tenants were away

Vulnerable Population Abandoned

The displaced population included elderly residents with mobility limitations, disabled individuals requiring accessible housing, and low-income tenants with no financial resources to secure emergency shelter. These individuals were left without:

- Safe alternative housing during a respiratory pandemic
- Access to their medication, medical equipment, or personal documents
- Municipal assistance or tenant-protection intervention
- Legal recourse despite clear violations of state and local law

Multiple complaints filed with SDCI specifically identified vulnerable tenants by name, described their disabilities and medical conditions, and pleaded for immediate intervention. Each was closed the same day with no action taken, no welfare check conducted, and no referral to social services.

Timeline of Systematic Failure

July 29, 2020

Complaint #006275-20CP filed documenting no fire exits and illegal unit conversions. **Administrative closure same day** with no inspection conducted despite life-safety hazards.

August 18, 2020

Three complaints filed in single day: **#007153-20CP, #007155-20CP, #007163-20CP** reporting mass eviction, boarded windows, armed guards, and utility shutoffs. **All closed administratively same day.**

September 16, 2020

Complaint #007945-20CP explicitly states "locked out, door boarded" with photographic evidence. Marked "Voluntary Compliance" and **administratively closed** despite clear involuntary displacement.

April 2022 - March 2023

Elevator and fire-system renewal invoices issued totaling \$1,558.98. **\$663.68 remains unpaid** as of case documentation date, with no enforcement action.

August 12-13, 2020

SPD issues "Notice of Closure" ordering immediate vacancy and scheduling walkthrough. **No tenant-protection action taken** by SDCI despite active eviction moratorium.

September 1, 2020

Complaint #007180-20CP details black mold contamination, no hot water for weeks, and armed intimidation of tenants. **Administrative closure with no investigation.**

July 27, 2021

Housing Code Notice of Violation finally issued listing **148 life-safety violations** with fines of \$150-\$500 per day. Issued nearly one year after forced evictions, long after tenants displaced.

2023 Record Tampering

Complaints **#009932-23CP and #009933-23CP** discovered with intake dates in August 2020 but 2023 record numbers, **proving retroactive re-numbering** of original complaints.

This timeline demonstrates a coordinated pattern of administrative neglect spanning three years, from initial complaint closures through retroactive record manipulation. Each failure point represents a missed opportunity to prevent tenant harm and enforce existing law.

Inspection & Enforcement Breakdowns

1

Same-Day Administrative Closures

Between July 29 and September 16, 2020, at least seven documented complaints were filed with SDCI, each containing:

- Specific allegations of illegal eviction activity
- Photographic evidence of boarded exits and changed locks
- Witness statements from displaced tenants
- Proof of legal tenancy (lease agreements, rent receipts, utility bills)
- Documentation of the active state eviction moratorium

Every single complaint was closed administratively on the day it was filed, with no field inspection, no tenant interview, and no enforcement action.

This pattern of same-day closures during an active eviction ban cannot be explained as bureaucratic backlog or resource constraints—it represents systematic nullification of tenant protections.

2

Record Number Anomalies

Public records requests revealed critical data-integrity problems:

- Complaints filed in August 2020 were later assigned 2023 record numbers (#009932-23CP, #009933-23CP)
- Intake date fields show August 2020 dates while record numbers indicate 2023 creation
- Original 2020 complaint numbers appear to have been retired or deleted
- No explanation provided for the three-year gap between intake and record number assignment

This evidence suggests post-hoc manipulation of complaint records, potentially to obscure the volume of 2020 complaints or the pattern of same-day closures. Such manipulation undermines public accountability and may constitute falsification of official records.

3

Delayed Life-Safety Documentation

On July 27, 2021—nearly one year after the illegal evictions—SDCI finally issued a Housing Code Notice of Violation documenting **148 separate life-safety hazards**:

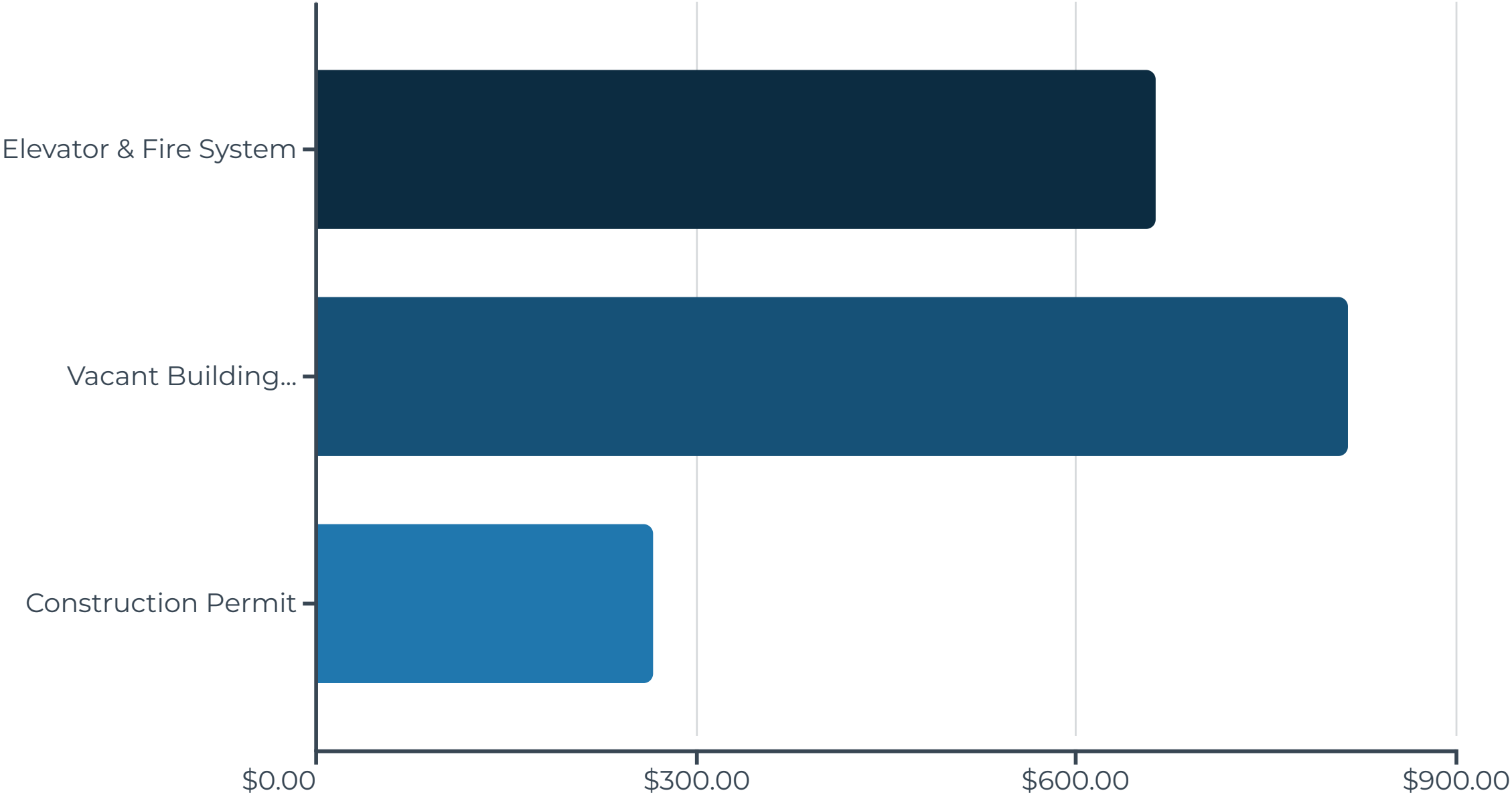
- Blocked fire egress routes (exits boarded or locked)
- Exposed electrical wiring throughout common areas
- Illegal unit conversions without permits or inspections
- Missing or non-functional smoke detectors and fire alarms
- Structural deficiencies creating collapse risk
- Mold contamination and water intrusion
- Failed heating and ventilation systems

Fines were set at \$150-\$500 per day per violation. However, this enforcement action came long after tenants were forced out, making it a hollow gesture that protected no one and recovered nothing for displaced residents.

The delayed issuance of the NOV raises critical questions: If inspectors found 148 violations in July 2021, those hazards existed in August 2020 when tenants filed complaints. Why were complaints closed without inspection when evidence of these very violations was readily available? The answer points to deliberate administrative choices to avoid enforcement during the moratorium period.

Financial & Regulatory Records

City billing and permit records reveal a property operating entirely outside regulatory oversight while the City continued to invoice for inspection services never rendered and fees never enforced.



RRIO Registration: Never Filed

SDCI permit database searches covering 1983-2025 show **zero rental registration records** for 8201 Aurora Ave N. Seattle's Rental Registration & Inspection Ordinance requires all rental properties to register and undergo periodic inspections. The Everspring Inn has operated as a rental property for over four decades without ever complying with this basic requirement, and SDCI took no enforcement action despite documented knowledge of the property's use.

Elevator & Fire System Fees (Record EQP-CY-04902)

Total Billed: \$1,558.98
Total Paid: \$895.30
Outstanding Balance: \$663.68

Renewal invoices dated April 18, 2022 and March 10, 2023 remain unpaid. The City continued billing for elevator and fire-system inspections while the property operated with expired certifications and documented life-safety violations. No liens were filed, no collection action taken, and no operations suspended despite non-payment.

Vacant Building Monitoring (Record 1051612-VB)

Outstanding Balance: \$815.55

Three unpaid invoices from February 5, 2021, May 6, 2021, and July 28, 2021 for vacant-building monitoring services. The City designated the property "vacant" for billing purposes while simultaneously treating it as occupied for elevator and fire-system inspection billing—a contradiction that highlights the incoherence of SDCI's regulatory approach.

Construction Permit Fees (Record 6279308-CN)

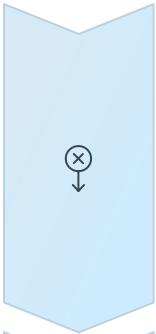
Outstanding Balance: \$265.50 (since April 21, 2011)

An unpaid construction permit balance from 2011 demonstrates over a decade of non-enforcement. This 13-year-old debt proves SDCI's pattern of invoicing without collection, allowing property owners to operate with impunity while maintaining the appearance of regulatory oversight.

Critical Contradiction: The City billed for elevator and fire-system inspections (treating the property as occupied) while simultaneously billing for vacant-building monitoring (treating it as vacant) and ignoring tenant complaints (treating it as unoccupied). This administrative incoherence allowed the owner to avoid accountability under any regulatory framework.

These unpaid fees prove that SDCI maintained continuous awareness of the property's status and operations, yet chose not to enforce registration requirements, inspect for safety violations, or protect tenants from illegal eviction. The City's willingness to invoice without enforcement creates a pay-to-play system where landlords can simply ignore bills rather than comply with housing code.

Policy Implications



Systemic Regulatory Failure

SDCI's pattern of same-day administrative closures effectively nullified state and local tenant protections during a declared public health emergency. When every complaint filed during an eviction moratorium is closed without inspection, the regulatory system is not merely failing—it is actively preventing enforcement. This represents a complete breakdown of the municipal duty to protect vulnerable residents, transforming SDCI from a regulatory agency into a rubber-stamp for illegal eviction activity.



Data Integrity Crisis

The discovery of retroactive record numbering—complaints filed in 2020 assigned 2023 record numbers with mismatched intake dates—reveals a critical vulnerability in public record-keeping systems. If complaint records can be renumbered years after filing, then:

- Pattern analysis of complaint closure rates becomes impossible
- Public records requests may return incomplete or misleading data
- Accountability for administrative failures can be obscured retroactively
- Statistical reporting on enforcement activity lacks credibility

This undermines not only public trust in SDCI specifically, but in the integrity of municipal data systems more broadly. Without reliable records, oversight is impossible.



Regulatory Incoherence

The City's simultaneous treatment of Everspring Inn as occupied (for elevator/fire billing), vacant (for monitoring fees), and unregistered (no RRIO filing) while ignoring tenant complaints creates a regulatory no-man's-land where no framework applies. This incoherence is not accidental—it allows property owners to avoid accountability under any specific regulatory scheme by exploiting contradictions between them. The result is a property operating outside all oversight while the City continues billing for services never rendered and protections never provided.

Precedent for Future Failures

If SDCI can administratively close complaints without inspection during a declared emergency, ignore an active eviction moratorium, manipulate complaint records post-hoc, and continue billing for unenforced services without consequence, then **no tenant protection policy has practical force**. The Everspring Inn case establishes a template for landlords to follow: ignore complaints, delay inspections, manipulate timelines, and rely on administrative inertia to avoid enforcement.



This case demonstrates that Seattle's current regulatory structure is fundamentally incapable of protecting tenants from displacement. Reform cannot consist of incremental process improvements within SDCI—the agency has proven it will not enforce tenant protections even during declared emergencies. Structural reorganization and independent oversight are essential prerequisites for any effective tenant-protection regime.

Recommendations

01

Independent Audit of SDCI Complaint Systems

Conduct a comprehensive third-party audit of SDCI complaint intake, tracking, closure, and record-numbering practices from 2020-2023. The audit must examine:

- Complaint closure rates during the COVID-19 eviction moratorium period
- Patterns of same-day administrative closures without field inspection
- Retroactive record renumbering and database manipulation
- Correlation between complaint closure and property owner/manager identity
- Billing and invoicing practices for properties with open violations

The audit should be conducted by an entity with no prior contractual relationship with the City of Seattle and should include forensic analysis of database logs to identify when and by whom records were modified.

03

Financial Clawback and Recovery

Pursue immediate collection of all outstanding fees associated with Everspring Inn:

- \$663.68 in unpaid elevator and fire-system inspection fees
- \$815.55 in unpaid vacant-building monitoring fees
- \$265.50 in unpaid construction permit fees from 2011
- Daily penalties from the July 2021 NOV (\$150-\$500 per violation per day)

Additionally, investigate whether any City, County, or State funds (including Rapid Re-Housing vouchers, emergency rental assistance, or other tenant-support programs) were paid to the property owner or manager. If such funds were paid while the property operated unregistered and in violation of housing code, pursue clawback and criminal referral for fraud.

Recovered funds should be placed in a tenant restitution fund for individuals displaced from Everspring Inn, with any remainder used to support tenant legal defense citywide.

02

Reopen and Reinvestigate Closed Complaints

All complaints filed against Everspring Inn between July 2020 and December 2021 must be formally reopened with full field inspections, tenant interviews, and enforcement action as appropriate. Additionally, SDCI should identify and reopen all complaints citywide that were:

- Administratively closed on the same day filed during the eviction moratorium period
- Closed without field inspection despite allegations of illegal eviction
- Subject to retroactive record renumbering or database modification

Affected tenants must be notified of reopened investigations and offered opportunity to provide updated evidence and testimony. Where illegal evictions are confirmed, the City should pursue maximum available penalties and coordinate with legal aid organizations to support tenant claims for damages.

04

Structural Reorganization: Seattle Tenant-Landlord Compliance Authority

The Everspring Inn failures demonstrate that SDCI cannot serve as an effective tenant-protection agency while simultaneously functioning as a permit and development facilitator. Create an independent **Seattle Tenant-Landlord Compliance Authority** with:

- Exclusive jurisdiction over tenant complaints, housing code enforcement, and eviction-law compliance
- Independent budget and staffing outside SDCI organizational structure
- Mandatory 72-hour inspection requirement for all tenant displacement complaints
- Blockchain-backed public complaint database preventing post-hoc record modification
- Tenant representation on governing board with voting authority
- Authority to issue emergency stop-work and stop-eviction orders
- Direct coordination with tenant legal aid organizations and housing advocates

This reorganization must be accompanied by whistleblower protections for City employees who report pressure to close complaints without investigation or manipulate records.

 **Immediate Action Required:** These recommendations require urgent implementation. Every day of delay allows additional properties to operate outside regulatory oversight and additional tenants to face illegal displacement. City Council should establish a 90-day deadline for audit completion and 180-day deadline for structural reorganization legislation.

Exhibits: Primary Evidence Documentation

The following exhibits constitute the evidentiary foundation for this case study. Each document is a matter of public record, obtained through Seattle's Public Disclosure Request process, SDCI's online permit portal, or direct tenant testimony. Together, they establish an irrefutable pattern of regulatory failure, illegal eviction activity, and potential record manipulation.

Exhibit	Description	Evidentiary Significance
A	August 2020 illegal-eviction narrative and complaint numbers	Establishes timeline of forced displacement during active eviction moratorium; documents pattern of same-day complaint closures
B	Complaint #007180-20CP – armed-guard intimidation, no hot water	Proves use of armed private security to intimidate tenants; documents utility shutoffs as illegal eviction tactic; closed same day without investigation
C	Complaint #007945-20CP – "locked out, door boarded"	Explicit statement of illegal lockout; photographic evidence of boarded entry; marked "Voluntary Compliance" despite involuntary displacement
D	Housing Code NOV – 148 violations, \$500/day fines	Issued July 27, 2021, nearly one year after evictions; proves violations existed during 2020 complaint period; demonstrates delayed enforcement after tenants already displaced
E	Elevator/Fire-System billing – \$1,558.98 billed, \$663.68 unpaid	Proves City continued billing for safety inspections while allowing expired certifications; demonstrates selective enforcement (billing without compliance)
F	Vacant-Building Monitoring fees – \$815.55 unpaid	Contradicts occupied status for elevator billing; proves City classified property as vacant while ignoring tenant complaints
G	Construction Permit fees – \$265.50 unpaid since 2011	Demonstrates 13-year pattern of non-enforcement; establishes SDCI's willingness to invoice without collection or compliance
H	No RRIO registration – SDCI site search shows none	Proves property operated as rental for 40+ years without required registration; screenshot of SDCI database search establishing zero compliance
I	Record-number mismatches (2020 intake with 2023 numbers)	Complaints #009932-23CP and #009933-23CP show August 2020 intake dates with 2023 record numbers; proves post-hoc record manipulation
J	SPD "Notice of Closure" letter ordering immediate vacancy	Dated August 12-13, 2020; proves police involvement in forced displacement; demonstrates coordination between SPD and property owner to circumvent eviction moratorium

Chain of Custody and Authentication

All exhibits were obtained through one or more of the following methods:

- **Public Disclosure Requests** submitted to SDCI pursuant to Washington State Public Records Act (RCW 42.56)
- **SDCI Online Permit Portal** public search function (permit and inspection records)
- **Direct Tenant Testimony** provided under penalty of perjury with supporting documentation
- **Photographic Evidence** date-stamped and geotagged where available

No exhibits have been altered, redacted (except for tenant privacy protection), or modified from their original form. All digital records include metadata verification where available. Physical documents have been scanned at 300dpi resolution and stored in tamper-evident PDF format.

Availability for Verification

Complete exhibit files are available for inspection by municipal oversight officials, investigative journalists, tenant advocates, and legal representatives. Requests for exhibit access should be directed to the case documentation coordinator, with appropriate privacy protections for displaced tenant identities.

Conclusion: A Roadmap for Accountability



The Everspring Inn case file now provides complete documentation of a catastrophic regulatory failure that spans three years, multiple city agencies, and dozens of illegally displaced tenants. This is not a story of bureaucratic inefficiency or resource constraints—it is a record of deliberate administrative choices to ignore tenant protections during a declared public health emergency.



Illegal Evictions Ignored

Multiple documented complaints of illegal lockouts, utility shutoffs, and forced displacement during Washington's COVID-19 eviction moratorium were administratively closed without inspection or tenant-protection intervention.



Same-Day Complaint Closures

Every complaint filed between July and September 2020 was closed on the day of filing despite photographic evidence, witness testimony, and proof of legal tenancy—a pattern that cannot be explained as anything other than systematic nullification of tenant rights.



Life-Safety Violations Spanning a Decade

148 housing code violations documented in 2021, unpaid inspection fees dating to 2011, and zero RRIO registration since 1983 prove long-term regulatory neglect. The City billed for services never rendered while allowing hazardous conditions to persist.



Evidence of Record Manipulation

Complaints filed in 2020 later discovered with 2023 record numbers and mismatched intake dates indicate post-hoc database manipulation, potentially to obscure the volume and pattern of complaint closures during the moratorium period.

This Integrated Dossier Provides:

- 1

Verifiable Grounds for Legislative Action

City Council has sufficient documented evidence to justify immediate investigation of SDCI complaint practices, database integrity, and enforcement patterns. Emergency legislation should be introduced to mandate 72-hour inspection requirements for displacement complaints and establish independent oversight of complaint closures.
- 2

Basis for Financial Recovery

Over \$1,744 in unpaid fees plus daily penalties from 148 NOV violations constitute recoverable municipal revenue. More importantly, if any city/county/state housing assistance funds were paid to this property owner while operating unregistered and in violation, criminal fraud referrals are warranted.
- 3

Foundation for Structural Reform

The creation of an independent **Seattle Tenant-Landlord Compliance Authority** with blockchain-backed public records is not merely desirable—it is essential to prevent future Everspring Inn scenarios. SDCI has proven institutionally incapable of enforcing tenant protections, and incremental reform within its existing structure will fail.

The Evidence Is Irrefutable. The Pattern Is Clear. The Need for Reform Is Urgent.

Every day of delay allows additional properties to operate outside oversight and additional tenants to face illegal displacement. Municipal officials, tenant advocates, and investigative journalists now have complete documentation to pursue accountability, recovery, and systemic reform.

The Everspring Inn case study transforms from a single property failure into a blueprint for structural change. Use this documentation to demand answers, pursue enforcement, and build a tenant-protection system worthy of a city that claims to value housing justice.